Your Faceless Reels Autopilot

Setup guide: one reel a day on Instagram + YouTube Shorts, made and posted by itself. Free.

> What it does: every day at 7 PM (India time) it picks the next idea from your list, finds free background videos, adds pretty text + music (optional AI voice), and posts the reel to Instagram and YouTube Shorts. It runs on GitHub's free computers, so your laptop can stay off.

Time needed: about 1–2 hours, one time only. Steps 5 and 6 (the Meta and Google developer screens) are the fiddly part — everything else is easy.

> **Stuck anywhere? Send Tab a screenshot on WhatsApp. Tab can walk you through each step.**

What you need

- Your laptop (only for setup)
- Your Instagram page switched to a Creator or Business account
- A YouTube channel and its Gmail account
- The folder faceless-autopilot.zip (from Tab)

Step 1 — Make a free GitHub account

1. Go to github.com/signup and create an account with your email.
2. Verify your email. That's it. GitHub is where the software will live and run every day.

Step 2 — Put the software on GitHub

1. Unzip faceless-autopilot.zip on your laptop (right-click → Extract All).
2. On GitHub, click the + (top right) → New repository. Name it reels-autopilot.

3. Choose **Public**. This keeps it free with no time limits and lets Instagram fetch the video. Your passwords and keys stay hidden in "Secrets" (Step 7); only your topic list is visible.
4. Click Create repository → "uploading an existing file". Open the unzipped folder, select everything inside it (including the .github folder) and drag it in. Click Commit changes.
5. Check that a folder named .github is listed. If it is missing, tell Tab, it's a 1-minute fix.

Step 3 — Free Pexels key (for background videos)

1. Go to pexels.com/api and sign up (free).
2. Click "Your API key" and copy it. Save it in your phone notes for Step 7.

Without this key the software still works, but uses random free photos that often don't match well. The key is strongly recommended.

Step 4 — Switch Instagram to a professional account

1. Instagram app → Profile → ☰ → Settings → Account type and tools → Switch to professional account.
2. Choose Creator (or Business). Pick a category like "Beauty" or "Digital creator".

With the method below you do NOT need a Facebook page.

Step 5 — Instagram access token (fiddly part 1)

1. Go to developers.facebook.com, log in with Facebook and click Get started (it may ask to verify your phone).

2. My Apps → Create app. Pick the use case for managing messages and content on Instagram, choose type Business, give it any name (e.g. Reels Autopilot).
3. In the app, open Instagram → API setup with Instagram login.
4. Under "Generate access tokens", click Add account and log in as your page (e.g. @dhruviverse.official). Allow everything it asks.
5. Click Generate token and copy it (it starts with IGAA…). This is your IG_ACCESS_TOKEN.

If it says your account needs a role: App roles → Roles → add your Instagram as Instagram Tester, then in the Instagram app accept the invite (Settings → Apps and websites → Tester invites). Your app can stay in Development mode; that's fine for posting to your own page. Meta renames these menus often. If yours look different, send Tab a screenshot.

Step 6 — YouTube connection (fiddly part 2)

1. Go to console.cloud.google.com with your YouTube Gmail. Create a new project called reels-autopilot.
2. Search for "YouTube Data API v3" at the top → Enable.
3. Open Google Auth Platform (OAuth consent screen) → Get started. App name: Reels Autopilot, your email, Audience: **External**. Add your Gmail as a test user.
4. Important: on the Audience page click **Publish app** (status "In production"). If you leave it in "Testing", YouTube logs you out every 7 days.
5. Clients → Create client → type **Desktop app** → Create → Download JSON. Rename the file to client_secret.json and put it in your unzipped folder.
6. Install Python from python.org (tick "Add Python to PATH").
7. Open the folder, click the address bar, type cmd and press Enter. In the black window type:

```
pip install -r requirements.txt
python tools/get_youtube_token.py
```

8. A browser opens. Pick your YouTube account. Google says “hasn't verified this app”. That's normal, it's your own app: Advanced → Go to Reels Autopilot → Continue.
9. The black window prints 3 lines: YT_CLIENT_ID, YT_CLIENT_SECRET, YT_REFRESH_TOKEN. Copy them.

Step 7 — Paste your keys into GitHub Secrets

1. In your repository: Settings → Secrets and variables → Actions → New repository secret.
2. Add each one (name exactly as written, value = what you copied):

```
PEXELS_API_KEY
IG_ACCESS_TOKEN
YT_CLIENT_ID
YT_CLIENT_SECRET
YT_REFRESH_TOKEN
```

Optional: GH_PAT (Step 9, auto-renews the Instagram token) and GEMINI_API_KEY (free AI captions, turn on in config.yaml).

Step 8 — Run it once

1. Open the Actions tab. If asked, click “I understand my workflows, enable them”.
2. Click Daily reel → Run workflow → set Post to **no** → Run. Wait 3–5 minutes.
3. Open the finished run → Artifacts → download reel and watch it.
4. Happy? Run it again with Post = **yes**. Check Instagram and YouTube.

From now on it posts every day at 7 PM by itself. The Run workflow button is your “post now” button.

Step 9 — Keep Instagram connected (optional, recommended)

Instagram tokens last 60 days. The software renews it at every run, and it can save the new one by itself if you add one more key:

1. GitHub → your photo → Settings → Developer settings → Personal access tokens → Fine-grained tokens → Generate new token.
2. Repository access: only reels-autopilot. Permissions → Secrets: Read and write. Generate and copy.
3. Add it as a secret named GH_PAT (Step 7).

Skip this, and you just repeat Step 5 every ~50 days and update IG_ACCESS_TOKEN.

Changing things later

- **Your ideas:** open topics.yaml on GitHub → pencil icon → edit or add blocks → Commit. 32 ideas are already there: tips, facts, quotes and Meesho finds, rotating.
- **Stop one type** (e.g. quotes): in config.yaml remove "quote" from content_types.
- **AI voice:** in config.yaml set voiceover: true. For a Hindi voice, change voice to hi-IN-SwaraNeural.
- **Your own clips:** drop faceless videos in assets/my_clips and set background_source: "mixed".
- **Posting time:** edit .github/workflows/daily-reel.yml, the line cron: "30 13 * * *". That's in UTC: India time minus 5:30 (13:30 UTC = 7:00 PM IST).
- **Music:** add .mp3 files to assets/music (YouTube Audio Library or Pixabay Music). Never Bollywood/trending songs: they get muted.

Honest limits

- **YouTube private uploads:** for years, Google locked uploads from new, unverified projects to Private until

the project passed an audit. Google's own upload page (checked 26 Oct 2026) now says unverified projects are not restricted to private. If your Shorts still show as Private, switch them to Public in YouTube Studio and fill in Google's "YouTube API Services audit" form. The software warns in its log when this happens.

- **Instagram video link:** Instagram downloads the video from a public link. The software uses a temporary GitHub Release (deleted after posting) with a free file host as backup. This step could not be tested on a real account before you set it up. If Instagram refuses it, Tab can switch you to the direct-upload method.
- **Trending audio** can't be added by any software (Instagram only allows it inside the app). Reels use the bundled music.
- **Free limits:** GitHub runs public repos free with no minute limit (private: 2,000 minutes/month, a run takes ~3–5). Scheduled runs can start 5–30 minutes late. YouTube allows plenty of uploads per day for this; Instagram allows far more than 1 post a day.
- **Stock look:** Pexels clips are free (credit lines are added to captions). For a more personal page, mix in your own clips.
- **If a day fails**, nothing breaks: the other platform still posts, the video is saved in the run's Artifacts, and GitHub emails you.

Ready? Start with Step 1 and message Tab whenever you get stuck. Send a screenshot and we'll fix it together.